invasive species is often successful, but it can also kill native species and undermine soil health, with the added threat of harm to humans.

One frequently used method of control, known as biological control, or "biocontrol," pits an invasive species' own enemies against it. In an early success, the cactus moth was introduced to Australia from South America in 1926 to feed on the prickly pear. This plant had itself been introduced in the 1770s and was choking farmland in New South Wales and Queensland. By the early 1930s, most prickly pears had been eradicated.

Not all biological controls are effective, and some measures have had disastrous consequences. For example, in 1935 cane toads were introduced to Australia to control the invasive grayback cane beetle, which was destroying sugar cane fields. The cane toad had been effective in controlling beetles in Hawaii, so the assumption was that it would be equally successful in Australia. However, grayback cane beetles feed primarily at the top of sugar cane stalks, which is out of reach for the cane toads. A lack of understanding of the different environments favored by the two creatures meant that the cane toad was the wrong choice as a biological control. By the time the mistake was realized, the toad had spread throughout Australia, poisoning any predator species that tried to eat the toxic amphibian.

Even when biological controls curb an invasive species, they may create imbalances in ecosystems or the economy of local communities. Regulators are, therefore, often hesitant to support biological controls without extensive prior research. No magic bullet exists that can control every invasive species. They are dependent on complex ecosystem interactions, and scientists continue to design field experiments to test their hypotheses of how invasive species function in the wild.